

The Best Places to Eat Pasteis de Nata

Antiga Confeitaria de Belém

moderate

Despite the charms of the riverside in Belém, it's hard not to make a beeline for the Antiga Confeitaria, the "old pastry shop," but you can reassure yourself that it's just as much a cultural highlight as the nearby monastery and other attractions. The busy, traffic-choked street outside gives way to a typically Portuguese tiled and polished interior, the vaulted rooms lined with antique *azulejo* tiles. There's a bustling carry-out counter and café tables inside, and while a score of different cakes and pastries vie for attention, there's only one real choice for aficionados – a *pastel de Belém* (ask for *pasteis de Belém* if you want several), made to the same recipe since the shop first opened in 1837. They're sprinkled with ground cinnamon in the traditional manner (not all cafés serve them this way), and while most Portuguese people would take one with an espresso coffee (known here as a *bica*), it's also perfectly in order to have a pot of tea.

Rua de Belém 84–92, Belém, Lisbon; open Jun–Sep: 8 AM–midnight daily; Oct–May: 8 AM–11 PM daily; www.pasteisdebeleem.pt

Also in Lisbon

To enjoy a custard tart with a view, try the elegant if slightly touristy cafés on central Lisbon's main square, the Rossio, or the stately **Confeitaria Nacional** (www.confeitarianacional.com; moderate) on the adjacent Praça da Figueira. Other famous cafés in the capital, each with tantalizing cakes and pastries, include **Martinho da Arcada** (+351 218 879 259; moderate), an old literary haunt under the arches on Praça do Comércio, and the uptown and very ornate **Café Versailles** (+351 213 546 340; moderate).

Also in Portugal

There are traditional cafés in every town and city that serve an excellent *pastel de nata*. In Porto, try the beautifully decorated **Café Majestic** (+351 22 200 3887; moderate). In the medieval university city of Coimbra, the **Café Santa Cruz** (www.cafesantacruz.com; inexpensive) serves delicious *pasteis de nata* in the vaulted rooms of a former monastery.

Around the World

In any city with a large Portuguese population, from London to Luanda, you're sure to find a *pastel de nata*. It's a different matter just across the border in Spain, however, which has its own, very different, pastry-making heritage. But in Barcelona's excellent **A Casa Portuguesa** (www.acasaportuguesa.com; moderate), a deli/café in the hip suburb of Gràcia, they serve a *pastel de nata* every bit as good as those made in Portugal.



Above *Pasteis de nata* are traditionally served warm, often with a generous sprinkling of cinnamon

Right Home of the *pastel de nata*, the Mosteiro dos Jerónimos in Belém is a much more elaborate confection, in Portuguese late-Gothic style

